

Kamla—acknowledged as the main inspiration for the book with daughter Pratibha—was present on the dais for all the launches. While BJP is used to Advani's family members riding on the rath along with him and sitting in the audience at various party functions to hear him speak, this extension of Brand Advani has taken the rest of the NDA by surprise. It is parivar politics of an alto-

1995, it was by his old friend and the then Congress prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao. Other Congressmen like Shivraj Patil were in the audience. "Recently, Advani had told Rahul Gandhi we are political adversaries not enemies. If they did not come to the release, he had the goodwill to go across and present his book. This is *bharatiya parampara*," defends Venkaiah Naidu,

secretaries of BJP had said of Advani, "in him we have a firm leader, ideologically committed and organisationally strong." This was the Advani that led BJP from two seats to 180. Why gamble on an image change now when he has everything going for him? He has the blessings of the Sangh and firm control of both BJP and NDA leadership. Why is he trying to become Vajpayee Lite when his party is quite happy with vintage Advani—an ideological fighter and a master organiser?



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THE HARDELL

■ **March 19:** Book launch in Delhi attended by most of the NDA and BJP chief ministers and Sharad Pawar. The glitterati included Sanjay Dutt, Anil Ambani, Sunil Mittal, Sonu Nigam. The set was designed by Nitin Desai.

■ **March 20:** Visits Vajpayee, has tears in his eyes as he gives his friend a copy of the book.

■ **March 22:** Calls on Sonia Gandhi with his wife Kamla. It is a 20-minute meeting but no photo-op is allowed at 10 Janpath. Later visits Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

■ **March 25:** Flies to Mumbai. Presents a copy to Bal Thackeray. Attends a book signing function in the afternoon and the launch in the evening. Amitabh, Aishwarya, Pandit Jasraj attend the do.

■ **Book launches in Ahmedabad, Kolkata and Bangalore.**

WRITE OCCASION: (From left) Aishwarya Rai, Amitabh Bachchan, Advani and wife Kamla

Soon after his visit to Sonia, a meeting which 10 Janpath barred from the media, the Congress went into a book-review overdrive. At Rahul's suggestion, the party is planning to bring out a booklet debunking Advani. These include his assertion that he "did not know" of Jaswant Singh's decision to accompany the three terrorists to Kandahar. "This leads us to the inevitable conclusion that he was India's weakest home minister," thundered Congress media chairperson Veerappa Moily. With the Congress planning to raise this issue in Parliament, BJP is left redfaced and without an explanation for a controversy it thought it had long buried. Congress spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi says, "All the wrongs in the NDA rule are being laid at Vajpayee's door and all the rights are Advani's." That may be a misreading of the book, which has brought out the man and his mind. It is the "vision thing" from a man who could be prime minister.

The question now is: which vision will Advani sell as the nation gets ready for the general elections? The reconciler who leaps out of the pages of his memoirs may win friends at book launches, but can he win India? Will the core constituency of the BJP come to terms with him? For the die-hard votaries of Hindutva, an Advani in a bookshop signing copies of his autobiography is not an ideal sight. For them, he is the chosen charioteer. When the destination is so near, why this makeover? Advani, at last the singular leader of his party, knows that he can afford it. He has written his story. To write the last chapter, he needs inputs from those who are not usually found at book launches. Now begins the harder life beyond the pages. ■

THE WORD I." — ADVANI AT HIS BOOK LAUNCH

gether different kind. But for Advani, his family has always been an essential part of the package. He has never downplayed their importance in his life and his politics. So much so, when Pratibha gave the vote of thanks, she was congratulated on her "maiden speech" by a friend. Laughing she asked, "Am I Rahul Gandhi that you are calling this a maiden speech?"

To look prime ministerial, Advani perhaps realises the need to be more than what he is. When a book of Vajpayee's poems was released in

a known Advani loyalist. In reaching out to his political adversary, Advani was trying to live up to his advice to young Rahul. It was meant to be the grand gesture of a man who can rise above petty political differences. Those in the party who dumped him when he went to meet the "secular" Jinnah were all for this grand gesture as he reached out to 10 Janpath. Advani has come a long way indeed. Cross-border peace missions are easier now for the supreme leader of BJP.

A decade ago, one of the general